

Pads to Launch your Game on

The often sidelined gamepad is slowly comming into its own. We invited the best to thrash it out in our tests and here we bring you the results

Gamepads are the most versatile of all gaming devices since they operate with almost every game. The cheapest gamepad for our tests came from Frontech. The best of the best came from the Logitech stable with cordless technology on offer, albeit at a price. The other competing vendors were Typhoon and Saitek. The ones that really shocked us were the ones from Microsoft which were aggressively priced.

Digit Test Process

We tested the gaming devices on our test-bench comprising a Pentium 4 2.2 GHz on an MSI 845E MAX2 BLR motherboard, 256 MB DDR RAM and a 40 GB Seagate ATA IV 7,200-rpm hard drive running Windows XP. Four primary parameters were considered: features, ergonomics, build quality and value for money. Each parameter was assigned a weightage of 25 per cent. The overall scores were then calculated from these. Features: For evaluating the gamepad features, we took into account various parameters—a USB interface scored better than a game port interface. The presence of both analog and digital controllers fetched some extra points. The number of programmable buttons was also taken into account. The presence of a throttle and niche features such as rumble effects, motion sensor and cordless technology got some extra points. Ergonomics: We awarded more points to gamepads that had large comfortable grip handles with anti-slip materials. Gamepads with a comfortable grip that offered optimum angle between the two handles was suitably rewarded. The spacing of the buttons, the angle at which they are placed to the thumb, etc was also taken into account. Build quality: The build quality was evaluated on various factors such as quality of materials used, button quality and feel, etc. For overall fit and finish, we noted the panel gaps, the sturdiness of the battery compartment flaps and the squeaking made during a good thrashing.



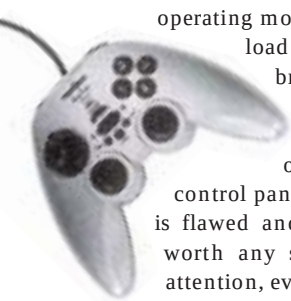
- Before buying a gamepad, check the interface on your computer. If you have a USB port, go for a USB device; else go for the old game port interface.
- Ideally, a gamepad should have at least six standard buttons, one eight-directional D-pad and two shoulder-mounted triggers.
- Gamepads are more suitable for playing arcade games, side scrolling games or sport simulation games. Hence don't buy a gamepad if you want to play only flight simulations.
- For smooth and linear control, opt for game pads with analog controller sticks.
- Hold the gamepad in your hand, and check whether you are comfortable with the button layout, D-pad, etc.
- Check the length of the cable—it should be at least 4 feet long.

Frontech JIL-1736 Fantasy Pad

Features: Eight programmable buttons, two analog controllers, one D-pad Price: Rs 850 Contact: Jupiter Infosys India Ltd Phone: 022-2001211/2001212 E-mail: frontech@bom5.vsnl.net.in Web site: www.frontechonline.com

The Fantasy pad from Frontech features the patented silver-black two-tone colour finish. The handles are too close to each other and rather too big. The D-pad has a good tactile feel and quick response. The buttons are not properly laid and the analog sticks are placed very close to them. The analog sticks are over rubberised, making them sticky and uncomfortable when used for long periods. The four shoulder-mounted trigger buttons are too loose and very tacky.

A mode button toggles the game pad between analog and digital mode. A small LED just above the mode button indicates the operating mode. To install the pad, plug into a USB port and load the accompanying driver. The pad can be calibrated through the game controller options in the control panel. The JIL-1736 is flawed and certainly not worth any serious gamer's attention, even at Rs 850.



Frontech JIL-1736 Fantasy Pad		B-
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	

Logitech WingMan Cordless Rumble Pad

Features: Cordless, rumble effects, D-pad, 11 programmable buttons, two analog controller sticks, a slider throttle Price: Rs 4,999 Contact: Aditya Infotech Ltd Phone: 022-26338555 E-mail: sunil_zarekar@adityagroup.com Web site: www.logitech.com

This Rumble Pad was the only wireless contender in our tests. It is quite heavy but this doesn't affect the game-play or strain you. The analog sticks are extremely smooth and responsive. The throttle is placed just above the right trigger button and provides a good response.

The pad uses 2.4 GHz radio frequency signals and can be used from at least 20 feet away. It showed absolutely no lag time and bundles four AA Duracell alkaline batteries. The installation is effortless and the provided software takes care of the calibration and button-programming.

This one offers the best features, albeit at a price—Rs 4,999.



Logitech Cordless Rumble Pad		B+
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Build quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Ergonomics	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶▶▶	